political. For the moment we tried to function as a kind of peasants' Union (with non-peasants and even zamindars in control!) but we could not and did not desire to give up our political character, and the Government looked upon everything we did as political. The shadow of future civil disobedience also lay ahead of us, and if this materialised there could be no doubt that economics and politics would march together, hand in hand.

In spite of all these obvious hindrances, it was our effort throughout, from the time of the Delhi Pact onwards, to keep the agrarian question apart from the political struggle. The real reason for this was that the Delhi Pact did not put an end to it, and we wanted to make this perfectly clear to the Government as well as the people. In the course of the Delhi conversations, Gandhiji had, I believe, assured Lord Irwin that even if he did not go to the Round Table Conference he would not resume civil disobedience while the Conference was sitting. He would ask the Congress to give the Conference every chance, and to await its result. But even then Gandhiji made it clear that this assurance did not apply to any local economic struggle that might be forced on us. The U.P. agrarian situation was before us all then, because organised action had been taken in the U.P.; as a matter of fact the peasantry all over India had been similarly affected. During the Simla talks Gandhiji repeated this point, and mention was made of it in the published correspondence.[1] On the very eve of sailing for Europe, he

[1] The following letters were integral parts of the Simla Agreement of August 27, 1931:

*Mr. Gandhi to Mr. Emerson,* Secretary, Home Department, Government of India.

Simla,
August 27, 1931.

"Dear Mr. Emerson,

"I have to acknowledge with thanks your letter of even date, enclosing a new draft. Sir Cowasji has also communicated to me the amendments suggested by you. My colleagues and I have carefully considered the amended draft, which we are prepared to accept, subject to the following remarks:

"In paragraph 4, it is not possible for me on behalf of the Congress to subscribe to the position taken up by the Government. For we feel that where, in the opinion of the Congress, a grievance arising out of the working of the Settlement is not redressed, an inquiry is a necessity of the case, because of the fact that civil disobedience remains under suspension during the pendency of the